
SESSION 1C

THE CROSS & PRACTICE

GOD'S WRATH TOWARD SIN

God is holy. Part of his holy love for purity and goodness means that he must be opposed to sin. But there has not been a moment in our lives when our sinfulness has not violated and scoffed God's glory, presence, and sovereign rule. This conviction of sin is the beginning of a Christian journey. It's not only the beginning, it's the ongoing Christian journey. Lose sight of this, and our Christian walk will falter.

Yet, deep down in our hearts, there is a resilient pride that makes it difficult for us to grasp the reality of God's holy wrath, and the wonder of his mercy toward sinners.

When God's justice falls, we are offended because we think God owes perpetual mercy. We must not take His grace for granted. We must never lose our capacity to be amazed by grace. ...

I remember preaching a "practice sermon" in preaching class in seminary. In my sermon I was extolling the marvels of God's grace. As the hymn says, I spoke of "God's grace, infinite grace."

At the end of my sermon the professor had a question for me. "Mr. Sproul," he said, "where did you ever get the idea that God's grace is infinite? Is there absolutely no limit to His grace?" As soon as he asked that question, I knew I was in trouble. I could quote him chapter and verse of the hymn that taught me that, but somehow I couldn't come up with a single Scripture verse that taught God's grace is infinite.

The reason I couldn't find any Scripture passage to support my statement is because there is none. God's grace is not infinite. God is infinite, and God is gracious. We experience the grace of an infinite God, but grace is not infinite. God sets limits to His patience and forbearance. He warns us over and over again that someday the ax will fall and His judgment will be poured out.¹

- R.C. Sproul, *Holiness of God*

Somewhere deep inside, in the secret chambers of our hearts, we harbor the notion that God owes us His mercy. Heaven would not be quite the same if we were excluded from it. We know that we are sinners, but we are surely not as bad as we could be. There are enough redeeming features to our personalities that if God is really just, He will include us in salvation. What amazes us is justice, not grace. Our tendency to take grace for granted was powerfully demonstrated while I was teaching college students. I had the assignment

¹ Sproul, R. C. (2008-09-18). *The Holiness of God* (p. 127). Tyndale House Publishers. Kindle Edition.

of teaching a freshman Old Testament course to 250 students at a Christian college. On the first day of class I went over the course assignments carefully. My experience taught me that the assignment of term papers required a special degree of explanation. This course required three short papers. I explained to the students that the first paper was due on my desk by noon the last day of September. No extensions were to be given except for students who were physically confined to the infirmary or who had deaths in the immediate family. If the paper was not turned in on time, the student would receive an F for the assignment. The students acknowledged that they understood the requirements.

On the last day of September, 225 students dutifully handed in their term papers. Twenty-five students stood, quaking in terror, full of remorse. They cried out, "Oh, Professor Sproul. We are so sorry. We didn't budget our time properly. We didn't make the proper adjustment from high school to college. Please don't give us an F. Please, oh, please give us an extension."

I bowed to their pleas for mercy. "All right," I said. "I'll give you a break this time. But, remember, the next assignment is due the last day of October." The students were profuse in their gratitude and filled the air with solemn promises of being on time for the next assignment.

Then came the last day of October. Two hundred students came with their papers. Fifty students came empty-handed.⁹ They were nervous but not in panic. When I asked for their papers, again they were contrite. "Oh, Professor. It was Homecoming Week. Besides it is midterm, and all of our assignments are due in other classes. Please give us one more chance. We promise it will never happen again."

Once more I relented. I said, "Okay, but this is the last time. If you are late for the next paper, it will be an F. No excuses, no whining. F. Is that clear?" "Oh, yes, Professor. You are terrific." Spontaneously the class began to sing, "We love you, Prof Sproul. Oh, yes we do." I was Mr. Popularity.

Can you guess what happened on the last day of November? Right. One hundred and fifty students came with their term papers. The other hundred strolled into the lecture hall utterly unconcerned. "Where are your term papers?" I asked. One student replied, "Oh, don't worry, Prof, we're working on them. We'll have them for you in a couple of days, no sweat." I picked up my lethal black grade book and began taking down names. "Johnson! Do you have your paper?" "No sir" came the reply. "F," I said as I wrote the grade in the book. "Muldaney! Do you have your paper?" Again, "No sir" was the reply. I marked another F in the book. The students reacted with unmitigated fury. They howled in protest, screaming, "That's not fair!" I looked at one of the howling students. "Lavery! You think it's not fair?" "Yes," he growled in response. "I see. It's justice you want? I seem to recall that you were late with your paper the last time. If you insist on justice, you will certainly get it. I'll not only give you an F for this assignment, but I'll change your last grade to the F you so richly deserved." The student was stunned. He had no more arguments to make. He apologized for being so hasty and was suddenly happy to settle for one F instead of two. The students had quickly taken my mercy for granted. They assumed it. When justice suddenly fell, they were unprepared for it. It came as a shock, and they were outraged. This, after only two doses of mercy in the space of two months.

The normal activity of God involves far more mercy than I showed those students with their term papers. ... We have come to expect God to be merciful. From there the next step is easy: **We demand it.** When it is not forthcoming, our first response is anger against God, coupled with the protest: "It isn't fair." We soon forget that with our first sin

we have forfeited all rights to the gift of life. That I am drawing breath this morning is an act of divine mercy. God owes me nothing. I owe Him everything. If He allows a tower to fall on my head this afternoon, I cannot claim injustice.²

- R.C. Sproul, *Holiness of God* (emphasis added)

Write a short response to the above excerpt regarding demanding or expecting mercy.

GOD'S WRATH & HIS LOVE

God is morally pure, and the manifestation of God's moral purity is necessarily wrath towards sin. We must not mistake his forbearance and long suffering as a lack of wrath on God's part. If you are morally pure, you are going to have wrath towards sin.

Let's think about that. We don't have access to actual moral purity, but we can get close by some examples. Let's say that you became an aunt or an uncle, and your niece or nephew just takes your heart away. Through that nephew and that niece, you begin to see the world as a potentially dangerous place that can harm the child you love so much. Before, when you heard about child molesters, you were just disgusted. But once you genuinely love your nephew and niece, that love manifests itself as wrath towards child sexual molestation. We want to remove them far, far away from children.

How much more would God? God is holy. He is full of love, which means **He has a settled opposition toward moral impurity that manifests itself as wrath.**

If we were to be able to clearly grasp the impact of our sins, all the victims of our cruel words, of our selfishness, envy, competitiveness, and manipulation, and if we were able to see all the people whose lives we failed to bless, all the things we left undone, all the people we ignored, all the ways in which we acted like we are regal and self-created, and we traced the damage and repercussions across relationships and across time ... it would be overwhelming. Mercifully, this is a picture we do not have the perspective to see fully. But God does. He sees it. He sees our sins in their full ugliness, and he sees the full wide-ranging impact of their rippling consequences.

² Sproul, R. C. (2008-09-18). *The Holiness of God* (p. 123-126). Tyndale House Publishers. Kindle Edition.

A GOOD GOD AND HELL

When we sin, we not only commit treason against God, but we also do violence to each other. Sin violates people. There is nothing abstract about it. By my sin I hurt human beings. I injure their person; I despoil their goods; I impair their reputation; I rob from them a precious quality of life; I crush their dreams and aspirations for happiness. When I dishonor God, I dishonor all people who bear His image. Is it any wonder, then, that God takes sin so seriously?

Hans Kung, the controversial Roman Catholic theologian, writing about the seemingly harsh judgments of sin God makes in the Old Testament, says that the most mysterious aspect of the mystery of sin is not that the sinner deserves to die, but rather that the sinner in the average situation continues to exist.

Kung asks the right question. The issue is not why does God punish sin but why does He permit the ongoing human rebellion? What prince, what king, what ruler would display so much patience with a continually rebellious populace?

The key to Kung's observation is that he speaks of sinners continuing to live in the average situation. That is, it is customary or usual for God to be forbearing. He is indeed long suffering, patient, and slow to anger. In fact He is so slow to anger that when His anger does erupt, we are shocked and offended by it. We forget rather quickly that God's patience is designed to lead us to repentance, to give us time to be redeemed. Instead of taking advantage of this patience by coming humbly to Him for forgiveness, we use this grace as an opportunity to become more bold in our sin. We delude ourselves into thinking that either God doesn't care about it, or that He is powerless to punish us.

The supreme folly is that we think we will get away with our revolt.³

- R.C. Sproul, *Holiness of God*

Some people say: "How can a good God send people to hell?"

Philosophically this is not a problem. The notion of a good God and hell are totally compatible. Because a good person naturally finds evil loathsome.

Take a look at yourself.

- Have you ever told a lie?
- Have you ever cheated?
- Have you ever secretly rejoiced over a friend's downfall?
- Have you ever manipulated others for your gain?
- Have you ever crossed sexual boundaries?
- Have you ever been cruel?
- Have you ever wished harm on someone?
- Have you ever wished someone would disappear?

When the above questions are posed to us, we find that the true answers to these questions are disturbing. We may succeed in not thinking about these convicting truths and their implications, but when we truly face them, the verdict is inescapable. The scriptures echo the same sentiments.

³ Sproul, R. C. (2008-09-18). *The Holiness of God* (p. 116-117). Tyndale House Publishers. Kindle Edition.



MARK 7:20–23 (ESV)

²⁰ And he said, “What comes out of a person is what defiles him. ²¹ For from within, out of the heart of man, come evil thoughts, sexual immorality, theft, murder, adultery, ²² coveting, wickedness, deceit, sensuality, envy, slander, pride, foolishness. ²³ All these evil things come from within, and they defile a person.”

2 TIMOTHY 3:2–5 (ESV)

² For people will be lovers of self, lovers of money, proud, arrogant, abusive, disobedient to their parents, ungrateful, unholy, ³ heartless, unappeasable, slanderous, without self-control, brutal, not loving good, ⁴ treacherous, reckless, swollen with conceit, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God, ⁵ having the appearance of godliness, but denying its power. Avoid such people.

ROMANS 1:29–32 (ESV)

²⁹ They were filled with all manner of unrighteousness, evil, covetousness, malice. They are full of envy, murder, strife, deceit, maliciousness. They are gossips, ³⁰ slanderers, haters of God, insolent, haughty, boastful, inventors of evil, disobedient to parents, ³¹ foolish, faithless, heartless, ruthless. ³² Though they know God’s righteous decree that those who practice such things deserve to die, they not only do them but give approval to those who practice them.

The witness of Scripture and our own inner convictions bear witness to our condition as sinners.

So the more difficult question ought to be, “How can a good God tolerate this?” Why does he allow human sin at all? Why are we not utterly destroyed?

If we think this is exaggerated, it’s probably because we have an ungrounded sense of human entitlement, this sense that “I am somebody.” We feel we shouldn’t be treated like this; we should not be held accountable for our sins, and we should be free to sin. Where do we get such notions? After all, we are creatures. We have no claim on God. God is not obligated to us. God is only obligated to his own nature, his holy character.

Yet, here we are filled with sin, and brazen about it. We are all, at some point, arrogant ingrates; two-faced hypocrites; liars and cheats; covetous, slanderous, proud and vicious. If a fraction of who we are were to be projected on a screen, we would be horrified. Yet before God, we think we are okay. We make sense of our own lives according to our self-proclaimed narrative. We look at the Bible, and its utter seriousness about human sin leaves us a little cold. We don’t feel it. God goes on and on in the Bible, prophets cry out a torrent of words against human sin, Jesus bled and died for human sin, and we still find it easy to believe that we’re not all that bad.

Those who continue to refuse God, trusting their feelings about themselves, in the end will have their way. C.S. Lewis said that in the end, there are two kinds of people: those

who say to God, "Thy will be done," and those to whom God will say, "Thy will be done." And that's heaven and hell. Hell is a place apart from God, which is what its dwellers wanted all along. There they cry, "Who are you to tell me what to do? I determine good and evil for myself, and as far as I am concerned, I'm good. One thing I will never doubt is my own goodness, my own 'okay-ness.' I am the measure of all things!"

Ultimately it's pride at the core, pride that refuses to submit to the truth and bend to God. When you're young, sin is not immediately costly. It even seems exhilarating. You feel like you're getting away with it. But you won't get away with it for long. Not in your thirties, and certainly not eternally. God's holiness is the shape, the deep structure of reality. To violate that consistently means that your life will get destroyed.

So take these three thoughts: God's holiness, sinful humanity, and eternity. If you consider these facts—a holy God, my sin, and the reality of eternity—there's only one conclusion. It's hell for us all, but for the cross of Jesus. Eternity for any sinful person will have to be eternity apart from God, because God is utterly holy.

Review these verses and note words you can relate with.



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So take these three thoughts: **God's holiness, sinful humanity, and eternity.** If you consider these facts—a holy God, my sin, and the reality of eternity—there's only one conclusion. **It's hell for us all, but for the cross of Jesus.**

Please write a personal response of 1 or 2 truths that convicted you from this session.

THE CROSS

The cross of Jesus addresses us as sinners before a holy God. In the context of eternity, judgment, human sinfulness and God's holiness, the cross means that wrath is mercifully, miraculously averted. The wrath I deserved was poured out, not on me but on Jesus, the sinless, perfect, eternal son of God. It all falls on Jesus on the cross.



2 CORINTHIANS 5:21 (ESV)

²¹For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God.

On the cross, Jesus absorbs all our sins and dies, as the timeless, eternal, once-and-for-all sacrifice for all human sin. He extracts your sin out of you. He draws it all out of you and it all goes on him. He becomes the most loathsome thing in the universe. According to 2 Corinthians 5:21, he who knew no sin became sin and took on the wrath of God. In exchange, not only is wrath averted, but wonder of wonders, we "become the righteousness of God."



ISAIAH 6:5-7 (ESV)

⁵And I said: "Woe is me! For I am lost; for I am a man of unclean lips, and I dwell in the midst of a people of unclean lips; for my eyes have seen the King, the Lord of hosts!"

⁶Then one of the seraphim flew to me, having in his hand a burning coal that he had taken with tongs from the altar. ⁷And he touched my mouth and said: “Behold, this has touched your lips; your guilt is taken away, and your sin atoned for.”

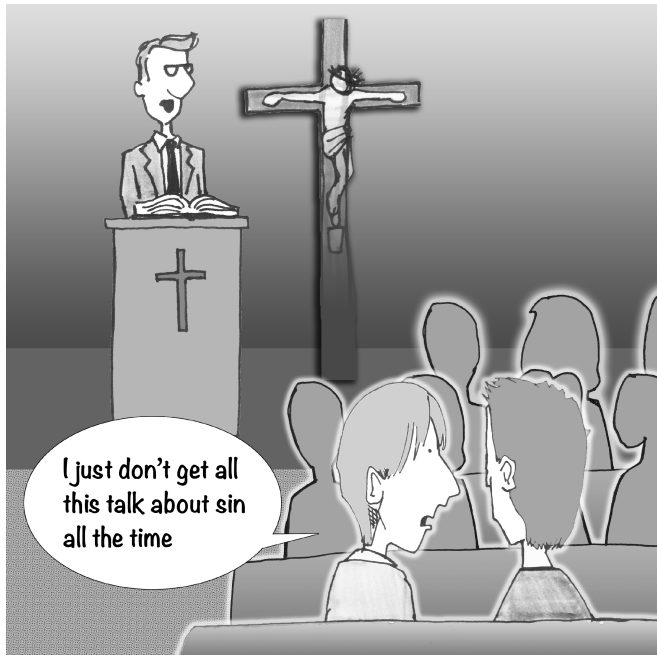
Once Isaiah pronounces a curse upon himself—“woe is me”—God does something. The seraphim comes with a burning coal and pronounces atonement: “Your guilt is taken away, and your sin atoned for.” God takes away the guilt when we declare a curse upon ourselves, i.e., when we see ourselves against his holiness and realize that we have offended and violated his character, and we declare ourselves guilty sinners deserving woe. Then the mercy flows from God’s altar, and the blood of Jesus cleanses us from sin.

The cross is like a multi-faceted jewel reflecting many truths. In it we see God’s love and his holiness. We also see our sinfulness. But we see our preciousness as well. It’s the cross that shows us, at the same time, who we are and who God is. Christ took the justice of God upon himself. His holy heart became blemished, stained, and ruined upon the cross. He took it all, and now he offers forgiveness.

Is this not the most awesome message any human being could hear?

Spend some time thanking God for the cross.

PITFALLS TO AVOID



Please use ideas, lessons, and verses from the material to answer these questions!

What is the relationship between not internalizing the truth about God's holiness and abusing God's grace (lack of seriousness towards sin); not putting in the effort for sanctification

What is the relationship between not internalizing the truth about God's holiness and lack of joy of salvation; serving God grudgingly, rather than with a sense of privilege

What is the relationship between not internalizing the truth about God's holiness and self-righteousness and pride, rather than gratitude and humility

What is the relationship between not internalizing the truth about God's holiness and Christian life being all about people and image-management